



(LEFT) SMRITI IRANI IN *KYUNKI SAAS BHI KABHI BAHU THI*; (BELOW) SAKSHI TANWAR IN *KAHAANI GHAR GHAR KI*; (EXTREME LEFT) *INDIAN IDOL 4* CO-HOSTS DEEPA KISHORE AND MEIYANG CHANG (RIGHT)



DECLINE OF TITANS

5%

was the average TVRs of *Kyunki...* and *Kahaani...* at the start of year which fell to 2.5 per cent for *Kyunki...* and to 3 per cent for *Kahaani...* last month.*

(* ALL DATA FROM TELEVISION AUDIENCE MEASUREMENT)

Reality formats are doing well, but only in spurts. In the past two months, 22 reality shows have been aired across Hindi entertainment channels. The burnout rate is fast. *Nach Baliye 4* was in the top 10 for the first two weeks of its launch, as was *Indian Idol 4*. Viewers are responding to all this cannibalisation with a big yawn, which brings us to another unofficial commandment that has been shattered. That viewers want to see the same story every half hour. Clearly, they don't.

Loyalty to shows, not channels

There's no such thing any more as channel fealty. Viewers are flipping from a show on Colors to a programme on Star Plus. What's more, after 10.30 p.m. viewers in metros are shifting to other genres. Last month, for instance, after 10 p.m., the share of entertainment channels came down from 52 per cent to 43 per cent, while that of English entertainment channels went from 0.12 to 0.2, of English movies from 0.4 to 1 and of Hindi movies from 12 to 15 per cent. Soon, says Reliance Entertainment Chairman Amit Khanna, viewers will be loyal to parts of a programme, watching it in 10 minute capsules. So they can flip from the end of a soap to the end of an *Indian Idol* gala round or even a news bulletin.

This may well lead to shorter soaps, with none exceeding a year. Or better still, like the West, soaps moving to franchises, like *Friends* and *The Sopranos*. These will allow shows to both revamp and revitalise. Currently, channels think more programming equals better programming. But, without content variation, it does not. So far the rise in the number of new channels has only seen a decline in ratings. According to TAM, in 2004, 1.5 per cent of the total Hindi fiction shows had TRPs of more than 10. Now there are none. Similarly, in 2004, 0.9 per cent of all such shows had ratings between 8 and 10. Again in 2008, there are none.

Shock therapy

The search for shock has begun. Everyone wants out-of-the-box ideas. Even Zee TV is moving not one, but three of its shows from prime time, *Teen Bahuraniyaan*, *Waaris* and *Parivar*, a mix of *saas-bahu* politics, crime and small town girl-comes-to-Mumbai-struggle. Experimentation is the new elixir. Call it a *Kahaani Ghar Ghar Ki*, with a reality check. Or catch the marketing executive's desperate plea to the contestants of 9X's *Kaun Jeetega Bollywood Ka Ticket*, "I want blood on the floor."

The current transformation is not at par with the change wrought on Star Plus by *Kaun Banega Crorepati* in 2000, but it's close. But it's not entirely due to Colors. If *Jai Sri Krishna* is popular today, then it was built on the back of *Ramayan*'s success on NDTV. Imagine. If *Balika Vadhu* is doing well, then a lot of the credit goes to the Rajasthani ethos and "relatable woes" of *Saat Phere* and Star Plus' *Raja ki Aayegi Baraat*. If small is looking sleeker, it's because 9X already tried bigger, better, brighter, most disastrously in Balaji's *Kahaani Humaray Mahabharat Ki*. Perhaps the most important thing *Balika Vadhu* has brought back is what Jassi did at its height for Sony TV and *Saat Phere* did at the beginning for Zee TV: the power of a good story, told well, not a series of deafening gimmicks set in an air-brushed, multi-coloured, heavily made-up veneer.

Will viewers get used to a novel narrative style where a shot holds for more than 10 seconds, where the cultural context is not inevitably drawn from the pink walls of a Mumbai set, and where every episode doesn't end in a cliffhanger. And where change occurs in spades, not spoons? If *Indian Idol 4* compromised between youth and experience by pairing the sweet Meiyang Chang with the jaded Hussain Kuwajerwala, next time, they may just listen to the production house, and take a risk. Just go with the new. ■